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Death of Novela

Chapter 1: Little Big Bird

Relentless rain plunges on the towering jungle below, draining the sounds forming its own rhythmic beauty; able to be heard bouncing off each of the tree's unique leaves. The beautified euphony is outweighed by the harsh environmental conditions the jungle is facing. Overpowering crisp winds are thrashing the blue grass, blue trees, blue vines. Everything is blue on this planet... everything but the mud, fog, and dark ominous sky looking down upon this deadly planet below. Every now and then, thunder strikes, breaking the calming sounds of the rain; shock and fire. In the distance a tree recently hit, shines brightly in the dark sky. The quick fire that has started can be seen from far away, a beautiful sight, unable to last; rain wins in the end. All kinds of creatures try to escape and find shelter from the hellscape outside. Freakish bugs scale the barks of trees seeking shelter within its holes. Giant spiders return to their elevated caves away from all the wetness. Puddles begin propagating all over the jungle floor, covering all the blueish grass, transforming it into a slippery mud. While most creatures hide, some hunt.

Feet begin splashing throughout the puddle floors. Small feet that belong to a grungy squirrel that came bolting out from fallen debris that the storm produced. The creature is frantically running all over the jungle floor through the mud, trying its best to get far away from where it once was. Its fur is covered in dark brown mud and blood; her own blood. Her right ear was missing. Visible damaged tissue all around the area, bleeding all over her own muddy body. The sheer fear and will to live are visible in her bloody eyes. The movements she makes are frantic but calculated beyond belief; trying to survive at all costs. She is still able to traverse the jungles puddles with ease while injured... but so can it. Deafening sirens were blazing from behind her... looking for her; she was being hunted. These sounds were so loud and unique that they couldn't be reproduce by any creatures other than the ones making them. The screams were affecting the squirrel, forcing her adjust and modify her own movement's down due to the sheer panic they were bringing. She knew that any sound that she made would result in her untimely demise. While trying to remain calm, each motion she was performing were calculated with extreme focus; each step was quieter then the last. Twigs and puddles were things she was actively trying to avoid; the moist mud was proving to be her only option. The fog, the rain, and the noises that the storm was brewing was a blessing and a curse. It was hard for her to see, smell and hear the creature that was following her, but this also made it harder for the beast to track her too... its sight was not affected. After a few more agonizing steps, the squirrel found a long puncture within a fallen down tree. Believing that she was in the clear, she took the opportunity and entered the crevasse, now waiting to see if the right decision has been made. She waited; silence. More waiting; just the wind. A little more; just rain. With each minute going, it gave her more hope; she could not detect it.

Before the squirrel could react, a sharp drawn-out claw came rushing in from below, thrusting upwards into her newfound residency. While missing the squirrel at first, the claw slashed part of the tree, damaging it, leaving it more open. She was found, and she wasn't even alerted to the beast's presence. With escape no longer being an option, she could only wait until the beast chipped away at the remaining log until a kill shot could be landed on her. After the log was almost destroyed, the claws stopped. Booming noises came rushing in from the skies,

sounds that intrigued the beast; these were sounds that it had not heard before. In the sky came a compact spacecraft approaching downwards within the planet's range, coming in for a landing a good distance away from the beast. With curiosity in the beast's uncanny jaws, it directed its head towards the moons in the hellish night sky and produced a new strange noise. Then it started sprinting after the ship.

With the ship now getting closer to the muddy ground below, orangey blue thrusters started to erupt from nodes that were apart of the ships landing system. With one big blast coming from the nodes, the ship's movement switched to a vertical downwards, as it was now preparing to make a full landing in the middle of this jungle storm. Most of the vegetation surrounding the ship begun to fly away due to the strong energy that the flames were producing. The ship then came crashing down into the mud. The force that the landing had produced, made mud from below it shoot out in a spiral motion, caking the ship and the surrounding jungle in mud, hiding the vibrant white the ship used to be. The ship's red label now almost impossible to read: *Little Big Bird*. That was her name, a ship that had seen a lot of crazy over the years... with more still to come. Inside the helm lay a woman, she was behind a fully digitized control board that was full of vibrant colors. As of that moment, she took her hands of the main steering mechanism and started pushing buttons to finalize the shut down process. She looked slightly stressed at this given time, but as a pilot she needed to remain calm and collected. With a small breath of air, and an earplug in her right ear listening to the latest hits from the Dupinger galaxy, she was back to reality, ready to continue her work. She then flipped a switch that was attached to a microphone, ready to break the news to the other occupants.

"This is Ash speaking. As requested, we performed a temporary landing on Novela's surface due to the weather conditions affecting our communications. Our current location is ninety miles off our agreed upon destination. Communications are still down, as I am unable to give a report to our current handler. I will write down the report in the meantime, so I can report back once the communications come back on. Over."

"Message confirmed Ashley. Darius and I will perform a quick inspection outside to check what the hell happened to our comms. It will probably be best to move once the storm outside clears, but our deadline is in two days, we cannot afford to miss it. Over," replied Tom. Tom is the leader of this expedition, he is currently playing cards with another man, Darius the mechanic; the only other person in this small crew.

"Guess we should start then," said Darius throwing his cards in the open, his face wielded with annoyance. Tom proceeded to grab most of the trinkets between them with a checky grin. After a good minute, they were up and ready, both equipped with outside gear to face the harsh weather outside. Bright lights begin poring outside from beacons attached to the ship, shining onto the muddy floor and illuminating the entire ship. A big hatch came crashing down, it created a ramp facing to the now ship's entrance. Tom and Darius came walking out, inspecting the ship. As they were walking through the wet mud, they turned their gaze to some wires that were attached to a small antenna. The wires were clearly damaged and the antenna at the top was burnt.

“Well shit,” Tom said irritably. “I’m sorry Darius, but this needs to be handled immediately. Given our small timeline, and with standards, we won’t accept the deal unless we can report back. So, we need these online asap or it’s a no go.”

With a quick nod from Darius, who was now clearly annoyed by the given news, Tom headed back into the ship. Darius followed shorty but turned at the equipment storage to get equipped with advanced gear to help climb the ship’s exterior, as the gunk would prove quite the challenge. With Darius busy, Tom entered the hull where he saw Ashley sitting, writing her report in precise detail. She quickly turned as she could hear the footstep that he was making.

“What’s the status?” Ashley said.

“Looks like a doozy, after your report, get some shuteye. Darius and I will remain up to fix it. The antenna outside is fucked, this will take us a while. Uh good night.” Tom was left standing, thinking.

“Why are you smiling,” Ash responded, pecking at the awkward silence.

“Oh, ah... Sorry.”, as Tom left trying to hide the small blush on his face.

With Tom now gone, and permission to get some early sleep, she quickly finished her report and headed towards the crew quarters. Not wanting to waste the opportunity, she decided to go to the showers and get a much needed clean before the boys did. After getting undressed and turning up music in her earphones, she turned on the hot water. This was needed, she was relishing from the water over her body, giving her head a much-needed refresh. After a while, the hot water and steam were lining the walls with condensation, hiding her from the outside world. Wanting to look at herself, she wiped off part of the mist revealing a large mirror. Looking at herself arose something in her, she froze. Her face filled with shock, and she started walking backwards. Something was clearly scaring her, but from the mirror’s perspective, nothing seemed to be out of place, it was just her normal self. While walking backwards, she reached the backwall as she then sat down on the shower floor huddling into a ball. She then started crying, the tears mixing in with the water going down the drain.

“Why did you do it Ashley? Why did you join the fucking *Blood Devils*? These are terrible people; they do things to people, things that no sane person should ever see. What would my parents think. It doesn’t even fucking matter what they think, goddam *Napkirály* soldiers took them, and what did you do Ashley, you joined a fucking cartel that deals with them. How would they react to their little daughter who joined the group that is partially responsible for their death. But what could I do, if I didn’t join them, I would probably be dead at the side of some road. But is this worth it? I’ve killed people, I’ve slept with some of the worst human’s known to man. Tom is the only reason I was able to escape Kolts, is this much better, how the hell is he ok with this.”

With Ashley remaining on the shower floor, Darius was outside enduring its shower. He was now located on top of the ship itself, tethered via harness and rope, trying to replace the dead wires. He was now much dirtier than before, bringing the mud from the ship onto him. The rain was still going strong; each drop was visibly sliding off Darius’s face, trying to get in his way.

These conditions were making it very difficult for him to work in but knowing full well that *Blood Devils* were people you did not want to be on the bad side of; the work went on. Each time he had to move to a new section, he had to be very careful. With the ship being a full-on slip and slide, any movement could result in sliding right off. With the right speed, and proper use of the harness, it didn't become much of an issue; just took him extra time. The amount of work that remained seemed impossible within the given time frame. In his professional opinion, this would require an extra day of hard labour, given the right circumstances. The worst part from this is that he will need to tell Tom of the news. His best move is to just continue working and wait until a good moment presents itself. This intern makes him switch focus to the main antenna itself. To his surprise, after a few adjustments a green light appeared.

"Tom, quick! I got a green light, try calling in."

It did not last. Before Tom could even try pulling out a device, the antenna sparked, turning it off.

"Fuck," Darius said.

"Well, it's something," uttered Tom as he came outside.

"Maybe," Darius replied, "If speed is the issue, you head back inside to the control board. If the light turns on, then I'll radio you, so be ready. I don't know if I'll even be able to reproduce it, but I'll try."

With Tom now heading back in, Darius pulled out a screwdriver and started deconstructing it. Before he could do much work, he heard some shuffling at the top of a nearby tree, prompting him to turn his head to inspect it.

"Hello? Eh, probably just a bird." Wanting to test his hypothesis, he pulled out a small flashlight and directed it to the noise's direction. He could barely see anything, but after hitting the right spot, a small black bird came flying out. "See, just a bird." As he pulled his flashlight back down the tree, he saw it... and it found him.

As Tom was inside, he passed the crew quarters where he heard the running water from the showers. He stopped for a split second and waited outside the doors as he quietly said to himself, "A man can dream." With that small pitstop, he continued heading towards the hull where he was about to get ready. Before he could do much, he heard screams coming from outside. At first, he thought Darius got the communications online but quickly realized that these were not happy screams.

"Holy fuck. Tom get the fuck out here. There is a goddam dinosaur. I need assistance... NOW!"

As Tom heard the screams coming from Darius, he knew something was going on. From his position, he wasn't fully able to hear the words that Darius was saying, but given the volume, he headed in his general direction. As he ran past the armory, he quickly grabbed a small firearm. Once outside, he saw Darius at the topmost part of the ship holding onto the tip. At the bottom he

saw a big creature trying to climb up to Darius. With a big jump, the creature landed on the lower part of the ship, not even slipping on the muddy surfaces.

“That’s a fucking Myrre,” Tom said, “get down,” as Tom started firing at the beast.

A Myrre... rare to the planet of Novela and almost exclusive to it as well. They are perceived as standout predators, being as close to the top of the food chain as possible, just under humans. Their intellect is unmatched, proven as they can handle any harsh terrain that is in their way, while also being able to hunt within them easily. While most creatures struggle in harsh environments, they persevere. They are also able to seamlessly adapt to new situations and threats almost instantly. They do this by recognising and remembering similar patterns that other creatures and terrains possess. After they face these new encounters, they learn from them, making sure they don’t make the same mistake twice. In some instances, learning while in a middle of an encounter. This is useful because as of recently a new spider variant has been able to overpower them due to a lack of knowledge, but they have been adapting making them evenly matched. Like humans they utilise teamwork, hunting in packs and sharing information. This is also what helps with their adapting; when one Myrre learns something, it shares the wealth of information with each other. While they can work together, they also are fully capable in hunting alone; one Myrre is more than enough to overpower most prey. Paired with their intelligence is their pure deadly nature. They wield sharp claws in forelimbs, allowing them to stab, climb, and break. With smaller prey like squirrels, claws are the weapon of choice; bigger prey they use jaws. Its maw is even deadlier than the talons. These sharp teeth can break mostly anything in its way, due to their sharpness but most importantly the sheer numbers. One hundred and twenty-seven teeth, that is how many they possess. The reason for so many lies in their head, in which the maw takes up the majority of it leaving one giant gapping mouth open for consumption. Strangely, they have no eyes... this, however, does not mean they cannot see. Scientists have discovered that they possess a weird quality they named *Color Vision*. *Color Vision* is a term used to describe part of the way they hunt. Using sounds, scents, and uniquely memories. Their brains are able to develop images from their own imagination that creates scenes for the surrounding area with high accuracy. With food being one of the most important items to them, anything they deem that they can eat shows a bright red smear; the tastier, the redder it becomes. Since Myrres can work with other Myrres, they show up as yellow smears, able to locate each other easily. The rest of the terrain are other shades of purple, green, and brown, all differentiated based on different types of terrains. Even new prey can be red from the start, as they possess similar patterns to other life forms. What helps *Color Vision* the most are the scent nodes that cover all over their body, making it hard for them to ever make a wrong calculation. While this is still an advanced concept for even some of the most regarded scientists, the technologies humans possess make mistakes rare; humans are still the most dominant creatures. At first glance, most think that they are related to the fallen velociraptor species, but these are anything but; only sharing the bird category. Myrres got the nickname *Borz Pszicho*, which translates to psycho badger, named after the honey badger due to the fact they are almost impossible to kill. The psycho part was due to photos of them showing their maw grimacing before they killed its prey, as if it was insulting the meals upcoming death. While only having one pair of limbs, they could run at human like speeds. Small wings on their back don’t allow them to fly, but allows them to

propel themselves at very high speeds in the air. Rare cases found they can use them in their own death rolls similar to alligators. With all its dangers, it was surprisingly a dying species. While it can kill almost any creature, its breeding patterns are vastly complex meaning they rarely reproduce.

With the commotion going on outside, Ashley was still in the shower washing her shame away. The sounds from the waterdrops, both inside and out were soothing, masking the screams outside. While Tom and Darius were busy facing demons, Ashley was washing her hair, unaware of the predicament they were in.

“Come on Ashley, you can do this, you have handled much worse.”

Gunshots then rang through the halls startling her. The water may be loud, but bullets are louder.

“What the hell was that?”

While most people would be scared from the sounds of nearby gunfire, Ashley was anything but, she was a trained *Devil's Blood*. Knowing the dangers that gunfire brings, she swiftly stormed out of the shower, almost slipping on the tile floor. She didn't even attempt to dry herself off or put on any clothing. If they were under attack, it didn't matter what she looked like. Like Tom, she did a quick pit stop at the weaponry, quickly holstering a pistol to her side, and a heavy shotgun with an attached sling at the ready. She then started heading towards the banging.

Outside, Tom's shooting was at first successful, he was able to get the Myrre's attention off from Darius; sadly, it was now on Tom. Not all was lost, his first shots were hits, puncturing the Myrre's thick skin; purple oozing from the holes. Unfortunately, these wounds didn't seem to deter the beast, it looked hungry. It jumped from the ship, landing within sprinting distance from Tom, like the beast, he was not willing to give up, not when he thinks he has the advantage. He started blasting again, but since this is a Myrre, it learned what his gun could do. With each shot, it was able to time them, allowing for it to dodge, knowing fully where the bullet's trajectory would lie. After a few more dodges, Tom heard a click... he needed to reload. It then started sprinting.

Darius didn't waste time; he took the opportunity to try and get off the ship while it was after Tom. The weather proved to be the ultimate challenge; as he was climbing, he slipped on the muddy surface, falling directly into the mud below. As he got up, he heard screams. Without a firearm, Darius knew he had nothing to provide, so he started rushing into the woods, leaving what was left for Ashley. He didn't make it far, as he was running, another Myrre jumped out from the trees and tackled him, knocking him into the wet sludge. All he could muster was: “Wait,” as the beast's full maw opened engulfing his head within.

As Ashley came rushing out of the ship, she saw Tom lying on the hatch door bleeding in pain. Next to him was the Myrre about to claim his meal, his mouth wide open. She took one second to raise her shotgun and blast. The creature tried to move, applying the same logic to her gun as it did for Tom. Unfortunately, not knowing the difference between a shotgun and a pistol

cost it. As she fired her gun, the Myrre was still within the blast radius. Sections of flesh came flying off, some of the creature's mouth was removed in the process. It wasn't enough though, it was still standing, purple now gushing from its face, leaking on the body of Tom. While it was still alive, it was critically injured. As Ashley pumped her gun for a second shot, the beast decided this was no longer worth it and left the two love birds.

"Holy shit. Tom, are you ok," she said as she rushed over to his body. She immediately tried cleaning his face from the purple blood, trying to find the wounds. If Tom had any chance of living, Ashley was his best shot; she did have decent medical training. Looking at the wounds, she was distraught from the amount of damage done, "Ok, I'll be back with some supplies," Ashley said. Before she could continue, Tom grabbed her head, pulling her down towards him. While this was happening, a claw came rushing towards her face, but due to Tom intervention, it was only able to rip a piece of her left ear. She tried to grab her gun, but the creature was able to put a claw in it, as she was pulling the sling ripped making the gun fall to the floor below the hatch door, all Ashley got was the ripped-up sling.

"Get inside the ship Ashley and lock the fucking doors. This is a Myrre, and they're fucking crazy. I'm done anyway, save yourself" spurted Tom, blood coming out from each word.

Ashley fully realizing the situation she was in, nodded as she got up and rushed back inside, trying to close the doors behind her.

"Take this you demon fucker," were the last words from Tom as he continued to fire his gun from the ground as the Myrre quickly walked on top of him, stabbing the remaining life he had. The creature did this swiftly, not wasting any time, as she was back after Ashley in a matter of seconds.

While the doors were closing, the beast was faster. While the doors did not fully close, the automatic system was blocking enough making it unable to enter. The creature however was relentless; it was banging at the doors trying to rip them open. It was doing considerable number of damages, visible dent clearly made. She was now trapped, naked and afraid and soon after, a second Myrre came banging at the door as well, its face bloody from the Darius it munched on earlier. She knew it was only a matter of minutes until they broke through. Not wanting to give up, she started running towards the armory to grab more firepower. Before she could even get close, the door burst open leaving two creatures onboard the ship. Panic set in as she did not have time to enter the padlock door in time, so she retreated to the crew quarters instead. She got behind a bed with her pistol at the ready. With a quick glance, she saw her music device lying on her bed which gave her an idea. She grabbed it and after a few button presses, a female voice started singing from the hull of the ship. Since Myrre's had no concept of music, they were a little confused as they headed towards the voice of Stacy Mundd missing the crew quarters entirely. To them they heard a meal that they could not smell. With them distracted, Ash took the opportunity to attempt an escape. She grabbed a couple pieces of loose clothing that were left about, wrapping them around her waist; most of which were not hers. She then stated sneaking, being able to get outside and see the remains of Tom. "What the fuck did I get myself into," she thought. Unfortunately for her, she slipped on the bloody door, sliding down to the mud below.

Knowing that the beasts were on to her, she started bolting into the forest passing the remains of Darius; reducing her hope, thinking that she would join him soon. The two beasts came rushing out, they were onto her trail. Gunfire could be heard from the jungle as they entered, small blasts of lights coming out of the trees. Soon after screams getting quieter and quieter... then nothing.

Chapter 2: The Divide

It was a murky room; dried blood painted all over the walls. Directly in the center was a man; like the room, he was a bloody mess. Possessing a face rough to look at, it being hidden from all his purple bruises. Beside him, two thick pipes, both reaching all the way to the ceiling. Attached were sets of chains, clasped to each of the man's limbs... crisscrossed. Each side of the man's limbs were attached to a different pipe. The shackles were sharp, digging into the man's skin; each movement tore more, hurt more... sitting situationless was this man's life. This was a prison, and he was its prisoner.

Unbeknownst to the man, he was not in any ordinary prison, this one wasn't even attached to any ground. Instead, he was being held captive on a ship of mass proportion, known to many as the *Hand of God*; a ship of mass destruction. It acquired its name due to its massive size, being bigger than most dwarf planets, but most importantly had resulted from its fire power, able to raise hellfire on all enemies, fully capable of destroying entire civilizations. This weaponry so far has only been used once, during the Two-Day war, fracturing the planet Koltz; Quadrillion lives gone in a matter of seconds. While capable of insane destruction, the cost to power an attack bankrupts' entire planets worth of wealth, making this weapon highly impractical.

A man soon came into the grim looking cell, covered in rich red clothing, showing the history of *László the One*; identifying clothes for a man of significant power. Behind him were two very formal men; his royal advisors... then he started talking to the bruised man, "I'm losing patience Quel, you are proving to be difficult, but I always get what I deserve, where is my sister. Oh, and please lie, I will torture you in new ways until you give me what I want, I am not the man you want to disappoint." This regal man is Morre Van Storm, leader of this vessel, actively looking for a promotion, to move back to his former glory of working for *László the One*, finding his sister is the only thing in his way.

"Mr. Storm, like I said before, I don't know any Victoria, I was at the wrong place at wrong time, I'm only a gully-vac" the prisoner pleaded. "Sadly, it looks like your being honest, and if you truly know nothing then I no longer need you." Before the prisoner could reply, Morre pulled out a small lavish knife, stabbing him in the lower abdomen, dragging it up. The prisoner wasn't dead yet, but he would be, leaving him to bleed out slowly.

When Morre stood up, cleaning his knife with some descriptive cloths, he looked to one of the men behind him, "Rick Steinner, you said you found someone with information, about the whereabouts of my sister, what happened?" "This task has been proving extremely difficult, most leads are ending up dry, no one seems to know where Victora is, I believe the people hiding her are giving us fake leads too" Rick replied. "The problem I have is that this is not your first offence. My limited patience is running out, and to remind, this organization doesn't like failure, so I'm going to have to fire you. You'll still be in a leadership position, but I'm moving you to the *Vitéz*, active immediately." No one wanted to work in the *Vitéz*, it was just fancy name for László's grunts or foot soldiers, a punishment given to members who couldn't keep up. Rick got

lucky, a leadership position wasn't certain death, it provides a chance to rise back up, something Morre is very familiar with. "Yes sir" was all Rick said as he headed out to his new life.

Morre now turning to his remaining advisor, "Eliza congrats on the promotion to my head advisor, your main task is to find my sister, your second is to find a replacement for your old one. And remember, don't fail me, we have less than four months before the *Templers Voice* is renewed, Rick will be more than happy to switch if you fail." With that Eliza took off, clearly looking conflicted, happy with the promotion, but fear for what that could intitle. With Morre now all alone with Quel, he pulled out a radio informing the clean up crew to clean the trash from the cell. He then went to his office waiting for the new royal advisor.

Morre's office upon the *Hand of God* was an expensive looking room; bigger than most people's houses. The walls were a sleek dark marble, imprinted with gold indentations, forming a palace like feel. A fountain in the middle, diverting into two branching paths ending in both sides of the walls. And it wasn't filled with water, but rich champagne, giving it a slight gold look; fully safe to grab a glass from. The main piece of the room was a cage filled with a small creature, it wasn't just any creature, but a baby myrre, a gift from a hunter for his birthday. Impossible creatures to obtain, but he got one... delivered in baby form; still an impressive feat for the hunter. "How are you doing Nathan, how's my killing machine" Morre asked the creature, "people may say it is impossible, but I am going to prove them wrong and be the first person to train a myrre. Would you like that, to eat all of my enemies."

Shortly after, a new man arrived in his office, cutting off Morre's pet talk. "Hi, uh... Sir Storm? I'm Clancy Hust, I was apart of the mission planning division, and I was informed by Eliza that I was to report here for a job opening." "That is correct... Hux, you are becoming one of my new royal advisors, Rick is currently getting a change of scenery." While Hust new Morre purposely got his name wrong, he knew better then to correct him. From this moment on, the person Clancy Hust didn't exist, the men in Morre's office were a Hux; "Yes sir." "I'll get right to the point Hux, I'll be needing you and Eliza to locate my sister Victoria Storm. She has done something very unforgiveable, and currently has some knowledge that must be silenced, I need her alive though. We have a timeline of four months... have you heard of the *Templers Voice* and the true nature of the Two-Day war?"

"Every prime number of years, in the templars calendar, activates the *Templers Voice*. A vision, it can allow mass destruction, but it can also allow life to entire civilizations. Who ever wields the vision, knows where to go and activate it, allowing them to change the fabric of the universe at their will. While we don't currently know the year the templars are currently in, our scientists are able to estimate when a vision may occur. It hasn't happened for over 1000 years, but it was predicted to happen fourteen years ago, on the planet of Koltz. I was there, and so was my sister. I was in a higher position of power, working directly under *László the One*, showing the ropes to the promising Victoria Storm, a soon to be leader, my sister. Our mission being to locate the vision, it was supposed to be a gift for László, allow him to shape the world to his liking. The issue that the vision brings is that only one being is able to view it, only in death will allow a new being to view it. Once we arrived in Koltz, we found it, a giant green crystal, bigger than me, but it was already taken. A kid, a small kid saw the vision, could have only been nine. I

ordered my crew to go down and apprehend him, we didn't want to kill him now and risk someone new taking his place, so we were going to take him and kill him once László was ready, to take the vision for himself. My sister did not agree with this, as a mother she couldn't live with herself doing this. She was planning on launching a typical blast at my troops, she did not expect to fire the *Hand of God*. This shouldn't have even been possible, the safety mechanisms failed to work, the ship was still being adjusted. But it happened, she killed quadrillions of lives in an instant, including the kid she was trying to protect. I was in shell shock, unable to process what had happened, then I saw her shaking, her eyes glowing, the *Templars Voice*. I looked outside the ship, the crystal still visible, unaffected by the now barren wasteland below, my sister was the first to look at it, claiming it. When I looked back, my sister was gone, escaped in a docked ship. She wasn't able to go to the required destination to activate it, with what had just happened, it would be suicide, so the vision went waisted. This accident was labelled the Two-Day war, blamed it on the rise of a rumor, a new rebellion. *László the One* somehow showed me mercy, I was demoted by record numbers, but I was not publicly executed. He said he saw great potential in me, said that I will probably be capable of re-rising the ranks. The last thing he said was that the next vision is luckily only in sixteen years, 'redeem yourself, and you will be highly rewarded'. My sister has been in hiding for sixteen long years now, somehow surviving to this day, László predicted she wouldn't live that long. The problem is that she still has the vision, so it is important that we find her soon, the deadline is in four months. I believe her goal is to re-write her mistake, reviving Koltz to its former glory."

After the long speech, he then got back to Hux, giving him a glass of champagne from his moat, "So that is why we need my sister within four months, it will allow me to regain my former glory, and least not forget about you and Eliza. If you succeed, you will have more money than you can count, you may even be in high positions of power." With a simple nod, drink, yes sir, and mandatory pet to Nathan, ordered by Morre himself, Hux left leaving Morre by himself. He had a quick glance at Nathan, "Do you think, will find him girl? I think will find her."

Chapter 3: A Gem Worth Finding

Moving trucks plowing through the blue forests of Novela. They aren't driving on any roads, instead driving in the middle of the forest, trampling down anything in their way, thanks to special dark reinforced plating on the hood, allowing demolishing anything in their way with ease.

There are four trucks total, a quick glance would provoke the assumption that they are part of *The Pillars of Napkirály*, but that's what they want, because it is farthest from the truth. In the distance, a giant mansion appears, hiding in the middle of the jungle, currently invisible from up above due to giant trees fully blocking the sky; the inhabitants do not want to be noticed. Around the mansions are two sets of prison fences, each handle sharp to the touch. The fence is also emanating a bright blue light do to large current of electricity. They do not want things in, but also they don't want the things between the layers out. Mulhound Spies, short for spiders, are dangerous deterrents. These spiders are big, the size of a person. Bodies are painted a dark-dark purple, with even darker red symbols across the body. Their webs are acidic, totally mute to their own skin, their bite is poisonous and corrosive, melting the insides of their victim. Very dangerous creatures to handle, this faction were only able to get them within the fence walls as eggs, allowing them to grow and breed within the confines of the walls. They aren't even native to this planet, exclusively located in their kitchen. The spiders do enjoy the new food source of birds: White Red-Beeks, Philly Metal-Peckers, and the Farland's crow.

At the front entrance of the fences leading into the building lies a woman, at the moment manning the entrance gate; Ruby Freeze. Once the four trucks pass the main gates, she closes them shut, keeping them in, but most importantly, the rest of the world out. At the front of the complex, an interesting looking man is standing waiting for them to stop.

As the trucks stops, group of armed men are getting out, they form in an orderly fashion forming all behind the front vehicle. Out of the front car, a beautiful lady comes out, dyed red hair, sleek body, and a pair of shades. None of this is for show, hiding the bruises and damages underneath. The man comes closer grabbing the briefcase she was holding, "Victoria Storm, Welcome to Novela" He said, "This is a dangerous place, few come here, and with the deterrents and banners most will assume this is a military base of *Napkirály*. This will be your home for the next few months until your codes can be excepted. My name is Shrek Kepler, and I will be your host and guard while in the Mac-Donder estate.

"Three months and two days" replied Vitoria, "that is how much time is required before the *Templers Voice* arrives, I am the only one who'll know where, and how to enter the divide. It's been ten years since the last, with my brother, and I know he'll be after me." "Victoria, until that time arrives, you'll remain a ghost."

Before the truck's arrival, some clicks due north in an open field revealed three grimy looking men. They all wore camo clothes, all colored blue openly matching the local fauna. The clothes were also caked in debris: mud, foliage, scratches; results from trekking trough Novela's

diverse fauna. They also wore protective hats, fitted with veils protecting their faces. From any glance, you could tell these people have been being busy in the wildlife. On their backs lye big back packs, capable of holding many a things. They also were packing weaponry, not of the military kind. Special cross bows, pale grenades, a multi-blaster, and a pistol for each; most on the side of their person. These were not normal people, these were hunters; hunters hunting illegally.

One of the men is on the ground placing bear traps. He is openly talking to the other two men about good hunting practices; he is the leader of this expedition while also being a teacher. “Rule one: know the best places where to place traps. These creatures are smart; they do not fall for openly laid traps. That’s why it’s imperative to hide them, luckily for us this planet has lot of good spots to place them. Now rule number two: know where you placed them. I don’t want to write to your mothers, but truth be told they probably would like it if you did step in one.”

The man talking was none other than notorious wildlife hunter Tanjam’andurra Lee Martin; master of the hunt. He has snuffed some of the most abnormal wildlife in this universe; turning him into a famous figure; both hated and loved by many. He is also praised by a high quantity of planets, most often working for their local government. Mostly involves either hunting beast annoying new construction sites or leader wanting a new mantle piece to liven their quarters. Unfortunately, most of his work does fall under illegal practices, his contacts with the contracting planets and *The Pillars of Napkirály*, give him practically universal diplomatic immunity. Even Morre has done business with him; had to acquire his baby myrre from somewhere. These contacts also enable him to get higher graded firearms, a lot of them experimental. They are currently wielding the *KLA dual-shock* crossbows that are not available to the public.

Now he is on temporary vacation, a man for hire for the ultra-rich; to go and learn how to hunt legendary beasts with the master. His current crew are just that, two rich friends wanting to put some wildlife decor in the office. Otso Alanko, and Giovanni Reizzoe; one is a lead advisor in weapons and acquisitions, the other is part of the banking industry, both wort billions of t-credits. These people were not looking to hunt for bears; they were hunting for myrres.

While Tanjam was setting up more bear traps, he started talking about their special features. “Now this red light on the side is a triggering flare, since we are setting these traps all over, these will be useful for information. Myrres are tenacious beasts, if we don’t know soon enough of the hit, they’ll break out. So when light goes up, we hunt.” While they were chatting and drinking; can’t hunt while board, Tanjam notices something in the distance, “Shut up Alanko.” In the far-far distance, Tanjam saw a myrre... all alone in an open field, asking to be served on a bun with mustard and relish. Just like the hunters, it was hunting, it just caught a rift squirrel; a squirrel but blue. It wasn’t a big meal, but food is food. “Get your bow ready Gio, see if your training paid off” Tanjam whispered. Tanjam and Otso soon lied on the ground with binoculars and rangefinders equipped. Giovanni readied his crossbow by setting up a tripod allowing maximum stability, his eye pressed to the scope. “Wind?” “Four knots east” replied Tanjam. “Distance?” “Sixty-five yards.” Giovanni adjusted his scope, trying to apply all of the

training he spent millions of credits on. “Ready to take the shot sir.” “Then Then fire when ready.”

When Gio clinched the firing mechanism, his heart slowed, making everything feel like slow motion. An arrow flying through the sky, glistening to those paying attention... then blood. It hit the unassuming beast, but it was still standing. The shock to the creature took a second, but after regaining its focus, it went running into the forest. “Well, you missed the vitals, but accounting for the long distance, that was one heck of a shot. Luckily for you these crossbows pack quite the punch.” Into the forest the myrre was running, it did get the small inkling it got away, unfortunately thanks to science, a sudden shock rippled through its body, powerful enough to take it to the ground. It wasn’t enough, it was still awake, motionless on the ground. Trying to use its little strength left to claw and inch itself back up. But then the second shock came... pitch black, the myrre now sleeping on the ground, the power of dual-shock, powerful enough to take down a myrre.

The hunters soon followed, tracking the splotches of blood it left while running. “Well Gio, you have the honors, claim your kill.” A knife then enters the beast’s neck, depriving the creature chance to wake up. Gio now covered in blood, finishes the cut, fully removing its head, “This is going on my office wall.” “Shut up Gio” Tanjam interrupted, something new caught his ear, something loud; definitely not a beast. They swiftly walked through more of the forest to see a unique sight for them, a mansion in the middle of the forest, fully gated on all side. Four trucks quickly entering. “Did we just discover a secret Napkirály military based” asked Otso. Every changed when the girl exited the vehicle. “Nope” replied Tanjam, “Call my friend Morre, tell him a storm is coming, on the planet of Novela. The hunt just got interesting.”

Chapter 4: Right Place, Wrong Time

A new spacecraft lies on Novela's grasslands. Surrounding the ship, bears vast forest in all directions, leaving this ship not wanting to be found. While the ship is lot smaller than most, this one in particular is an expensive piece of technology having more advanced features. It doesn't compete at the level of *Napkirály's* fleet of ships, but for independent buyers, it's hard to get anything better. The ship is labelled *Sole Survivor*, being one of the fastest on the market, but also one of the most evasive, making it a top choice for the more illegally motivated individuals. Equipped with fast hovers allowing quick and easy landings, making it good for hiding, requiring little space when taking off. When people see this ship, they know they have something to hide, or that they're a rich pompous ass.

Two dapper figures, wearing very formal attire are currently exiting the haul of the ship. Both are working together handling a label-less red crate off the ship, trying to place it in a presentable format of other matching crates along side the ships exterior. These crates do require two people to move them, them being the size of a single bed. The most recent crate placed are being managed by two bickering siblings, trying to lift it up to place on another create. Those two are Ace and Desiree Basile, brother and sister. They both have bright blue eyes, and dark black braded hair, both cut very short; cut for the workplace.

"I can't believe you got me tied up with *The Family*," the girl said.

"You and I both know, we need money. Moms is in bad shape, with the current economic crisis, she'll die if we didn't join," the brother replied.

"We also won't be able to help her, if were both dead. What we do can get us killed, these are powerful chemicals, and *Napkirály's* officers are notoriously bad at keeping inmates alive. Not to mention the people we are dealing too are some of the worst humans known to man. I even heard a rumour that *Good Time* got her name from what she used to do there."

"We won't get caught; I won't allow it. It's just this one job, then we leave. We'll have more than enough money to support her. And don't worry about these devils, they are nasty sons of bitches, but if we don't cause any issues, it'll end smoothly."

"For her sake, you better be right."

After placing the crate onto the other, they headed back inside with their now empty trolly, with the intension of grabbing another. While inside they meet two more men, dressed the same dapper way as them, who are getting their next crate ready.

"Merry Christmas," one said while giving the sibling duo their next crate.

"Thanks, *Bear Trap*," *Royal Flush* said.

While this crew is working together, hardly any of them knows each others' names; only the ones with pre-existing relationships do, like the two siblings. This is because *The Family*, the organization they are working under is a criminal organization. While some of these groups can do heinous things, most do it simply for money, and lack of it. Most planets end up poor, making

these one of the only ways of having financial stability; *The Family*, is one of those groups. That's why codenames are essential, using these reduces exposure. If one member gets compromised; it forces them to go down with the ship. These codenames also allow for easier communication; names won't be traced to their own when used abroad or over communication channels.

Ace got the nickname *Royal Flush*, due to his gambling problem. Desiree got *Straight Flush*, due to being related to him. The other two crew members are Hunter Fitzgerald, and Jaiden Becker; known to the rest as *Bear Trap*, and *Blue Jay*; both given based on their actual names. Hunter is a big man, with his luscious orange hair, beard and killer smile, most would assume he was a lumberjack in another life. Jay on the other side is a lot smaller, being the smallest in the crew. This does not affect him as he is able to hold his own wait in spades, also being one of the smartest. With the two siblings taking the crate away, both *Bear Trap*, and *Blue Jay* start working to get the last shipment off.

"This must be one of the biggest deals we've done, we'll all be spoiled after this," Hunter said.

"Just don't get caught, having this much money out of nowhere could be dangerous," Jay replied.

"Then what will your share?"

"I might visit the Saturn system; I got family there. With how my planet was managing the new rise of power, it made it almost impossible to go a visit them. May also be a good idea to move there permanently. They are being less affected by László's rule, you should come."

"You wish cute stuff. I have some contract with some knob head, most of my money will go to that. He saved a former lover of mine, owed him a big debt ever since. Funnily enough bitch left me shortly after, expected by his parents to join the troops, hope he's alright though; he owes me a lot of money... and a good time. Once this is all resolved, probably move back home and help with the family business, their good people. I might be up for your proposal if I get my life back on track but don't depend on it."

With the two siblings coming back, Jaiden and Hunter gave them the last shipment. Being clear for the day, the two went towards the cockpit to clock out for the day. Sitting in the pilots' seat was Ken Underwood; short for Mackenzie. Unlike the rest of the crew, he was the only one not dressed in presentable attire. This being as he was not apart of the dealing process. He's only the pilot; fly in, fly out. To the rest, he was simply known as *Kill Kenny*, and nothing more. As of now, he was planning an optimal route back towards HQ after the deal is finalized. The deal was not until the following morning, so he has plenty of time to plan a route that will minimize delay and problems from noisy *Napkirály* searches.

"Product is unloaded, any more tasks from *Tough Love*?" asked Hunter.

"Nah, your good. Remember, deal is at 0:600 so make sure your ready then," replied Ken. With a quick beep from the computer, Ken logged the two off for the day.

With that, the two left towards the dorms to get some shut eye for the upcoming deal. Shortly after the two siblings came in after finishing their work. Ace realized though that he had forgotten one of his tasks. "I forgot the crowbar; I'll be back in a second," he said. Going outside, all he did was place a crowbar next to the crates. When he was coming back in, he saw Artis Cliff filling the ship with some hydrogen fuel, he goes by *Missing Ear*. He got his name from painting during his spare time, a reference to a man from forever ago. Artis is bald with many tattoos all over his body; all of them black. As of now, he is handling the ships maintenance, following Ken's specifications. Ace gave a quick nod and went back to the dorms.

The next morning, Desiree woke up to see she was the last one out of bed. The time being 0:400 meant she had two hours to get prepared for the upcoming deal. When she was about done, and exiting the ship, she saw everyone else except one. About ten minutes later, Lily Calaway exited, clip board in hand. She was the leader of this venture and one to not mess around. She went by *Tough Love*, due to her rough and straight to the point nature. The crew knew better not to get on her bad side as she was known to be aggressive to people, she deemed not putting in enough effort. While being rough, she's used to seeing results, as she is very qualified at leading. She has longer hair than the rest and also wears shades and a hat.

"In one hour, three people representing the *Devils Breath* will be here to acquire eight shipments of Vermiliylen. Once they arrive, we will open one container or more, revealing the product. In exchange for these eight containers, they will give us nine-hundred thousand T3 credits. Once the transaction is completed, we will leave," Lily stated, hyping up the crew for the massive payday coming ahead.

With the time getting closer to the meetup, the once satisfied crew was looking less optimistic. Once the time hit, pure silence, no one knew what to do, no one showed up. Was this a prank, a setup, the crew started feeling concerned; concerned the paycheck wasn't coming. No payment for their mothers' surgery. No payment for moving somewhere safe. No payment to clear their debt, allowing them a free life. Lily was acting the tensest. This deal took very agonising months to prepare, only for no one to show up. She was pacing back and forth, fiddling her finger. The only option now was to wait. Maybe they were late. Maybe they were a bit behind. After an hour, the crew knew that something was off.

Lily wanting results, pulled out a communications device and started dialing a number on it. Nothing, no response. She tried again, pulling out a piece of paper to make sure she had the right number, still no response. This was making her more agitated. After each dial, the crew could see how angry she was getting. She knew how to keep her cool, but she just had that look. The crew knew that the next mistake would end in a fiery explosion. Beside her, filling out forms was the last member of the crew, and second in command, Cydney Bradshaw; *Good Time*. She is currently being trained by Lily to become a leader like herself. Lily sees a lot of potential in her, that she could lead her own crew at some point.

"You know the number they specifically told you not to call. I think you might need to call it. If someone fucked the buyers, we can't have them blaming us," Cydney suggested.

“Fuck! I think you might be right. They better have not set us up,” Lily replied. She then began to type a new number into the device, this one was twenty-four digits long, much larger than the first. “This better work.” Almost immediately, the call was answered. On the other end showed a wealthy looking bald man wearing black and red stripped clothing. Behind him were gold trinkets and fancy looking statues. This was not a man you wanted on your bad side.

“Well, if it isn’t Lily of the valley. I know something is up when you call, especially when told not to. What seems to be bothering you,” The man said.

“We are having... an issue with the deal. The buyers have not come. My crew has been patiently waiting for them, and I would not like to disappoint them after all the hard work they put into it. I’m calling to ask if anything has changed or if you have any info on their late arrival? As you can see, the product is all intact,” Lily said, while using the crowbar to open a crate showing the man some product. “As instructed, we tried calling the number provided, but each call led to no response.”

“As much as I hate being disrupted, you are correct that something has happened. Like you, they have not been responding to me either. Luckily for you, they never reported about leaving for the deal. That means your men aren’t responsible for their disappearance. To my concern, they failed, and if they are still alive, that won’t be the case for long. I am feeling however... extra generous. My intel suggests that the ship is still there, meaning that fat paycheck is unattended. The last update from them was yesterday on Novela. It’s only a hike away from the agreed upon destination, nothing your team can’t handle. I’ve uploaded the coordinates to find it. If you decide to take it, just leave the product where you are, and I’ll send a guy to pick it up later, everyone wins. Oh, and say hi to Cydney for me, tell her she’s welcome back anytime. Some of my men would be glad to spend some quality time with her again.” With that, the man on the device logged off.

“Bunch of dicks,” Cydney said. “Could this be a trap?”

“Even if it is, if they want us dead, leaving now won’t change anything. They’ll just kill us later. Our best bet is to head to the coordinates he gave us and hope we get paid. I’ll inform the entire crew of the update. Can you get the team Cydney?” Lily asked.

With the whole crew now all huddled together, Lily began to speak. “I just talked to a higher up about the situation, he suspects that his crew is dead. He also gave us info that their ship is still here, which he gave us the coordinates to, which I’ve sent to each of your devices. I’ll be sending a team of five to retrieve the payment, leaving *Good Time*, *Missing Ear* and *Kill Kenny* at the ship. If the payment is still there, we will be leaving the shipment here.

“Isn’t this just a trap?” Replied Desiree. “People just don’t end up dying. These Devils freaks are probably trying to give us up to *Napkirály*.”

“While this is a possibility, if they want dead, leaving only prolongs the inevitable. Best case is the payment.”

Before Lily could finish, a missile out of nowhere went straight into the hull of the ship. The blast from the missile was enough to puncture into the fuel tank, turning the missile explosion into the entire ship imploding. The shockwave resulted in the entire crew falling to the ground. Hunter being the big man he is, was the first to be able to see the result. A bright blue light of pure hellfire, melting what was left of the ship. A shine so bright, you could see the reflection clear as day in Hunter's eyes. This was no normal missile. This one came equipped with destruct thermite paste. Causing an initial explosion, followed by burning chemicals to melt anything it come to contact with. The reason why the missile was easily able to breach into the ship's fuel was due to the thermite melting all the way down. Hunter then realised that the fire was now moving towards the product relatively quickly. Knowing that this was bad news, he got up trying to aid the rest of the team escape the area. While most were now retreating into the forest, Artis and Becker were the only two left on the ground, both acting less responsive than the rest.

"Get up *Missing Ear* and *Blue Jay*," Hunter said while picking them up on his shoulders. Before he was able to evacuate, three orange sharp armor piercing blades went directly into his lower abdomen. This was enough to take him down, dropping the two in front of him. "Leave now," were the last words Hunter said, unable to now move due to the blades. The two knew he was done for, while they were able to move now, they were also injured making them move way slower than the rest. Hunter now lying on the ground, bleeding all over the dirt, he heard running coming from the other direction. A grunt, now after the two laggards was entering the blast zone, gun in hand. Before the grunt made it far, a couple of loud bangs could be heard making him fall to. Two bullet holes, right in his leg. While Hunter was critically injured, he was still able to pull out a standardized pistol, allowing his crew to escape.

Three more foot-soldiers charged into the inferno, hovering around the two grounded men. Two went straight for their fellow colleague, aiding the injured grunt by quickly removing the attire around his wounded leg, allowing them to apply a tourniquet to stop the blood flow. The third grunt went to directly to Hunter. Hunter did try to use his pistol for a second attempt, but with his critical condition he was unable. The grunt was easily able to kick Hunter's hand making the weapon fly out stumbling over the dirt far away. Before Hunter could react, he saw the back end of the man's firearm heading straight for his face. With a quick smack, Hunter was out cold, lying in the middle of the fire, still bleeding. He was about to head into the woods to give chase, but the fire had other plans. A quick fizzling bang got the attention of all three, the product was now hissing from the fire breaching into the crack that Lily opened. Before they had a chance to move it burst.

A giant orange smoke rushed out engulfing all five within. Electricity began shooting out of the smoke making a light show for the already beautiful sky of Novela. Rick Stiener, the former advisor of Van Storm can be seen entering the hellhole, just outside the reach of the orange cloud. He was wearing different attire from the rest, this being an outfit of a commanding officer; fitting as he is now leading this expedition of infantry foot men. Behind him now were a large amount of foot soldiers, more than what Lily's Family could handle. Once the dust settled, there was nothing... only a crater. The five former men inside the chemical reaction were reduce

to smoke, leaving nothing to remember them by. Part of the ship was inside the radius, leaving half the ship evaporated. The once beautiful ship was no longer structurally sound. It took about five seconds to fall apart into the hole. The soldiers behind Stiener were about to head into the woods but quickly halted.

“Wait, look at this,” Steiner said. He grabbed the left crowbar and used it to open a crate unaffected by the fire. “These aren’t the people we want; this is Vermilioylen. These are just some lowlife drug dealers. I’ll give them credit Vermilioylen is some dangerous shit. However, they’re irrelevant, forget them. We got other matters.”

With Steiner being recently fired from Van Storm, he has something to prove now if he wants it back. Now he’s been given an almost impossible task, obtaining the infamous Victoria Storm. Conveniently, a recent call from Tanjam’andurra lead them directly too this planet, they even have the location of the residence she is found in. They just accidentally discovered the *Family’s* deal location, thinking it was just a recon for Victoria. Deciding it would be optimal to remove it from the equation. Steiner believes that if he can succeed on apprehending Victoria, then he would be reinstated to his former glory, possibly even higher given if Morre gets a promotion. He was given a crew of twenty-six to start, now down to twenty-two, but given the importance, he ultimately has a blank check; allowing him to acquire anything he wants. This mission is so important that even László will give him anything he requests to acquire the girl.

Chapter 5: Corporate Ladder

Back upon the *Hand of God*, in a small but fancy corner office. A screen is currently on projecting the image of a man. Infront of the device is Hux wearing a headset, talking into it towards the guy on the other end.

“As you can see here, on the other end coming out of the first truck is one Victoria Storm. It looks like they have a small military operation inside of the mansion. These crazy people have the perimeter surrounded by Mulhound Spiders. Those are very poisonous and intelligent creatures. I’m impressed they were able to capture some. They aren’t even native to this planet,” the guy on the monitor said.

“Thanks, Tanjam. This information that you have provided will give you a giant sum of cash. Once we apprehend her, I personally will come down and hand you them, we just don’t want her to get away, so all effort will go to the capturing part first,” Hux replied.

After logging off, a red light at the door flickered. Then came in Morre Van Storm and Eliza Flippen.

“So, what’s the verdict?” Morre asked.

“I received confirmation that Victoria Storm is located on the planet Novela. Tanjam’andurra, the experience hunter who we have connections with, is the one that informed us of his discovery. He was on a hunting trip with some standard rich people, where he discovered her. He has also provided a video confirming her whereabouts, placing her in the Mac-Donder estate. From his information, they have a small militia protecting her, from the apparel, it looks like a local group known as *The Finches*. They also have Mulhound Spiders around the premises, probably a deterrent, even Tanjam was a little confused on how they got them. From the look of the emblems on the side, it seems they were trying to pass off the building as one of our military stations. Probably something along the lines of no one would investigate a military base from the Napkirály. In other news, Rick Stiener thought he discovered one of their recons and tried to silence them, turns out there are local drug dealers in the area, found Vermilioylen. We heard it was going to go to the Devils Breath, unlucky for them, half the shipment exploded killing some of our grunts. Most of the dealers were left to escape, keeping on route to the mansion.”

“I’ll keep you in here, we want to do this mission without making any alarms, we can’t give Victoria another chance to escape, deadline is coming to close. And Eliza, how is it that are new blood is able to get us quality leads so quickly?”

“To be perfectly lucky, Tanjam just happened to find her. I was just the one who picked up the phone, pure dumb luck.”

Chapter 6: Operation Storm Front

The ground is covered in orange sand; each gust of wind blows it into the face of people walking by. While not deep, only a initial layer of sand covering the brown rock below enables cities to be built on top of it. A vibrant city is incorporated, with modern looking houses to unmatch the ground below. Flags around each building showing the life of different cultures, the most prominent though is the flags of *Napkirály*. While the newish government needs to be shown, they do not make them exclusive, other cultures are allowed to exist but must acknowledge the people of the law.

Along the way are two colorful *Napkirály* soldiers scouting out a building ahead. Their clothes are different than the other soldiers, these are more greenish red highlighting the history that László wants in the fabric of the seems. It is also less advanced than the other. They also are wearing specialty face coverings and goggles to protect against the sand brushing against their faces.

“Nice to back to your home planet Arian,” one of the men said.

“Ya, I miss Constantine. It’s a lot different than I remember, I haven’t been back here in eight years,” the other said.

“Wow. Have we been soldiers for eight years. It feels like yesterday when we enlisted for László’s rise to power. That’s the reason why Constantine is more advanced than other planets; this is László’s home. He’s even the reason why we joined, as the popular action hero, young kids like us wanted to be like him.”

The two childhood friends are Arian Foster, and Lyle Hubiki. Former residents of the planet Constantine, now young soldiers for *Napkirály*. Constantine now becoming a leading planet in economics due to the connections to László not being as harsh as he has been to other planets. Hubiki’s hair is bright orange, blinding anyone who sees it when the bright sunlight hits it. He also has a tidy beard that is cleanly shaven every day to keep his signature look. He is handsome, never having trouble with the ladies. Arian’s face is clear, couldn’t grow a hair if he tried. With small black hair, he is also a lady killer himself. While the planet of Constantine thrives, hiccups to *Napkirály* still happen. Now, the two are looking at a building that is giving hiccups.

Three more *Napkirály* soldiers enter the frame with one having more distinctive clothes indicating a higher status than the rest. He is Zonder Horne, clearly younger than the rest, only in a high position due to his mother’s connections. Beside are Alan Pages, and Stacy Flynn; same level as Arian and Lyle.

“Status report Lyle,” Zonder asked.

“Weapons manufacturing plant. This does not fall under a branch related to *Napkirály*, meaning it’s illegal, with high probability of selling to the *Gauls*.”

“Then we have enough information to solicit an engage. Let’s roll.”

With that the team of five under the lead of Zonder started heading towards the building. Two workers were outside filling a truck with weaponry crates.

“Get on the ground with nothing dangerous in reach. We have high reason to believe that this is an illegal weaponry plant producing weapons to the *Gaul*. If you don’t cooperate, we will not hesitate to use firepower. Give up now and let us do an investigation to insure your livelihood,” uttered Zonder to the two workers.

The others knew an investigation would lead to death anyway. After all, Zonder was correct, giving weapons to enemies was a death sentence. Doing nothing also would lead to death, so they only had one option. One of them tried to reach a weapon to be able to fire back but it was pointless. With quick shots from Zander’s rifle left both bodies falling to the floor panting the sand below them vibrant red.

“Ok, they chose option two, firearms are engaged,” Zonder said.

Before he could finish bullets started coming from the window, firing at them.

“Get down,” Zonder yelled, pushing his team down away from the bullets.

While they are now the ones getting fired upon, they still have the advantage of high level training, that the window firer lack.

“Stacy, you have the high score back in the academy. I will draw them to fire at me while you move behind that car getting an angle. While that happens, you two lovebirds will go the other end to aid in the confusion. Alan you stay with me,” Zonder quickly ordered. With the crew now ready in position, Zonder starts firing back in a safe position. While he isn’t hitting anything, the others are keeping their focus. When his bullets stop and he reloads, the bullets come firing back at him. Stacy then came out immediately hitting one of the window people. With quick adjustment she is able to take out another. The other two people left start to turn their attention to her requiring her to go back under the vehicle. That split second allowed for Lyle and Arian to take out the two remaining targets leaving the streets quiet again.

“Ok, good work crew, you have been trained well. With that, the lovebirds will take the left entrance while me and Stacy check the rear. Alan you keep point here,” Zonder ordered.

With Lyle and Arian entering the building, they took no time shooting at anyone they found. Each one they shot had a weapon equipped, not giving up knowing they would be killed anyway. The screams in the halls were loud, even heard the bullets from far away from the team from the back. Old books flying from the bullets hitting them in the background. The enemies had no chance against these young soldiers of *Napkirály*, they were not even able to land a single bullet on them; they didn’t have any form of weapons training. After a while the bullet sounds and screamed died down; most of the combatants were lying, turning the former school halls into a red slip and slide. When Arian arrived at a stare case, they knew only one floor left.

“I’ll follow your lead Arian,” Lyle said.

With Arian going up the final set of stairs, an old lady was atop in the final room. She had a gun in her hands, shaking clearly not ready for what was about to come. When she saw Arian coming up, she hesitated; Arian did not. A single shot to the head was all it took, she fell making the former group fully wiped out, leaving only a path of bodies and bullets. When Arian starts checking out the room, he froze when seeing the body, a quick second later started rushing towards it.

“Mom... the fuck? Why did you join the Gaul. You knew I joined the army. What did I do. What the fuck do I do?”

Shortly, Lyle came rushing in, seeing Arian crying over the body quickly putting together what had just happened. He quickly grabbed Arian, pulling him away from the body.

“Listen to me. If they put this together, that this is your mother you could be killed. You need to understand that you did nothing wrong and need to collect your cool before Zonder gets in here and gets imaginative ideas. Can you do that for me?” Lyle asked.

With a quick nod, and few breathes, Arian stood up, weapon in proper position. He was still shocked and was keeping his voice to himself while arriving to the rest of the crew.

“Buildings clear. All combatants neutralized. Place is filled with illegal weaponry, ready to be picked up and handled,” Lyle summarized.

“Good job lovebirds, our end is the same. Mission complete. I’ve sent in word about the success and a clean up crew will be here to collect and clean this school. Stacy and you two go outside and wait with Alan while I’ll come up with a plan for the clean crew,” Zonder responded.

With the three heading outside, they saw Alan smoking, pack in hand offering to the rest. Stacy put up her hand allowing Alan to pass the pack in the air to her, taking out one for herself, and two for Arian and Lyle. Both accepted, now all of them smoking.

“We did good,” said Alan.

“Hell ya we did,” said Stacy.

“You know how much longer we have to stay?”

“Probably a while, looks like a big job for the cleaners.”

“Fuck I was planning on going to...”

Arian was not paying attention to the crew. He was looking at the school intensely, thinking about what had just occurred. The only thing he could do was smoke in to drown out the voices; it didn’t work.

“Was there anything I could have done different. Maybe my mom could survive if I noticed sooner. No. She would still be killed for her war crimes. I would be considered an accomplice a share the same fate. Why did she join, this place seems to be thriving, why help the lesser people. I need an answer, why?” He thought to himself.

A quick bump on his shoulder diverted his attention.

“Earth to lovebird, did you hear me? You want to go to the local club and snag some lovely girls after this is done,” asked Alan.

“You should, after this you need it,” asked Lyle, clearly wanting him to go to get his mind off the current situation.

Arian quickly looked back to the school, going right back to his thoughts. “Sure, it’ll be fun,” he said.

Fifteen years later, he is now looking at a crater. The planet is Novela, and the aftermath of the bust from them, mistaking them for Victoria crew. He is starting at it, just like the school.

“Give me a status report Zonder, who did we lose,” asked Rick Steiner.

“We lost four crew members, all evaporated, turned to nothing. From my crew count we lost: Quincy Adams, Sam Birkins, Blair Escobar... and Lyle Hubiki.”

Arian didn’t want to believe it; his childhood friend reduced to nothing. He was secretly hoping that maybe it was someone else in the blast. “I want revenge, I want to go after them,” he said.

“Can it *Lovebird*. These people are irrelevant. Stay on the mission, we need Victoria,” ushered Steiner.

Even though Zonder gave him the nickname, it ended up sticking due to the constant use from him. Now it feels even more demeaning for Arian, due to the other lovebird no longer alive.

“Zonder gather the troops, I will be talking to a higher up about the snafu and get accurate mission planning,” said Steiner

With the leader of the now 22-person team leaving behind a parked vehicle to a temporary monitor setup to talk to a higher up, it left the rest of the grunts to wait and talk to pass the time. The original crew from fifteen years ago are still together on this mission remaining close in their own little clique. While Zonder is not as close, he has self inserted to the un-liking of the rest. Funny thing; they are all on the same level due to some demotion relating his hot-headed nature. He does still get tasked the most with information due to the experience. Alan then pulls out his pack of smokes and passes them around.

“Sorry about Hubiki, I knew you two were close. I know it sucks, but that’s the life we signed up for. Death is around us, turning us into desensitized killing machines. You are luckily then some, you have been together for 23 years. I knew people who lasted only a month, good people. Let’s just have a smoke for him, he was a good one,” said Alan.

“I bet this info is fucked, has been for the past twelve years. They keep on sending us on bogus missions killing our fineness for it to always end in a bunch of hooley,” Stacy pitched.

“Ya, you three are lucky”, pointing at Alan, Arian, and Stacy; “Last year, we landed on Skorsiff about a new hot lead that ended in a massacre. Someone sent us false leads to an undercover ring of our own people. Ended in a lot of dead soldiers on both sides. Worse part, we had to cover it for the public, would have been a disaster if the public found us killing ourselves,” said Garvi.

Over the years the crew has expended to new members. The newest are an older gentleman named Grey Garvi. He is bald with a head that pulls it off. A little stubble on his chin finalizes the look. The other is Sarah Luxembourg, a new hire that connected fast with Stacy over their upbringings. She has something to prove being the youngest at the moment and mostly overlooked for her size. She has been able to hold her own placing average overall to not be last.

“We better find this girl. It has been way to long, 14 years of constant in your face bullshit that I want dealt with. Once we find her, we can get back to normal missions,” Sarah added.

Before more of the crew could continue, Steiner came back with an update. “We have proof that Victoria is located on this planet. The info has been provided from a hunter known as Tanjam’andurra giving us video evidence and constant updates from affair that she is located and remains under the Mac-Donder estate. We will be hitting the place at night to try and gain the element of surprise. And remember we want her alive, do not kill her, or you will be facing the wraith from Morre yourself. Also be prepared, they have surrounded the premises with Mulhound Spiders, they are not messing around.”

With the time passing, each minute feels longer. The team has been in this position before with each being a dead end. This time they have proof though, not shooting random buildings from fake leads. Once the time hits, they are moving in trucks towards the mansion. Before they get close, they stop getting out, they don’t want to take roads giving away their position so they start trekking in the vast forest on the path that will hit the side of the estate. Each soldier is wearing special kinds of glasses; these allow to see in dark areas. After trekking for two hours they arrive at the outskirt of the mansion looking in.

“Once we get the clearance to engage, we will enter quietly through the spider enclosure. Making a hole inside an outer wall, have your sound stopers ready.”

While most silencers on guns still make noise, these sound stopers are fully silent; expensive piece of tech.

Chapter 7: Alone

A woman's body is laying at the side of a riverbed, her body is moveless as the sun Betelgeuse rises in the distance highlighter her. She is covered in blood and dirt, all over her body which is naked. She has clothes rapped around her body with an empty holster attached to her hip. A small turtle coming from the water has found her restless body, it came up to her licking away at the blood coming off her.

She coughed. She coughed water out of her mouth, jolting her body to rise, facing the ground to allow the rest to come out. After a few seconds of agony, she got the rest of the junk out of her system. She looked confused, unable to match the surrounding area, in her mind the world was spinning. She fell back on the ground, the turtle rushing away, not wanting to deal with whatever she was dealing. After more passing time, with the sun fulling on her she woke up a second time. She tried to get up but pressure on her leg proved to be painful. She sat up and started to sit in a sited position to rest.

“Ashley, what the fuck did I get myself into.”

After a few seconds of accumulating information, she tried to think about how she got here. Her head, not In the right position putting all the hard work was able to put some of the pieces together.

She slipped on the door of the ship; she made a noise and knew that the Myrre beasts were on her trail. With no other option she started running in the woods hoping to lose the trail during the harsh storm that caused them to land the ship. Both other crew members were dead, killed by the beasts that were after her. Realising Tom was dead was hard for her to relive. As much as she hatted the guts of the Blood Devils, she had felling's for Tom. He saved her from the Myrre, he saved her when her parent was taken away; the only good man left, gone. She then remembers trying to shoot backwards into the trees at the beasts, she was only able to land a single hit on one with the rest missing. All she had was a pistol in one hand, and a ripped-up sling in the second. She suddenly stopped, a cliff, a waterfall. She was at the top of a waterfall with two beasts behind her about to get her. With no other option she remembers taking the leap, hopping that this jump would not be too far as to damage her. With knowing good formation, she got in an arrow formation to go through with minimal damage. Then the rest was a fog, putting the pieces together where that is how she got here.

Realizing that the three beasts could still be out there made her shoot up. The pain on her foot seemed to be bothering her, but knowing that she could be dead meat, she decided that would be the least of her worries. As she looked around, she didn't realize that she was covered in loose clothing the whole time. Most of these belonged to Darius, a size much larger than her. She was able to score a sweater, tank top, and sweatpants. All the clothing were wet, but this was the least of her issues. As she walked closer to the water, she saw the flow of the river. “I must have came in that direction” she thought to herself pointing in the opposite direction of the flow. She believed that her only way of survival would be to retrace her steps back to the ship, as other wise she we be left her, alone for the rest of her life. She didn't even believe she had that long, but determination took over saying that she needs to survive, no mater how.

Chapter 8: Front Storm Operation